

Conducting an Informational Interview

What an informational interview is:

- A 10- to 20-minute conversation with someone who knows things that you want to know
- An opportunity to learn something
- A chance to seek advice and information that will enable you to better position yourself for your intended career
- A way to build a relationship and expand your network

What an informational interview is not:

- A chance to ask about job leads

Tips:

- Conduct informational interviews throughout your career, not just when you're job searching.
- Don't include your resume in your initial email unless specifically asked to. Do include the link to your LinkedIn profile if you have a good one. It can be a nice addition to your signature line.
- Your initial email can set the tone for the relationship. Be confident but not arrogant, polite but not apologetic.
- Be prepared to ask questions of them and answer questions about yourself. Map out ahead of time what you'd like them to know about you, then weave those points into the conversation.
- Research thoroughly so you can ask questions that demonstrate your knowledge of your contact's industry and/or company.

Sample questions to ask:

- Can you tell me how you got to this position?
- What do you find most satisfying about what you do? What are some of your biggest challenges?
 - Make a note about their responses so you can send a "saw this article and thought of you" email later to keep the relationship alive.
- Based on your experience and observations, how do people break into this field?
- Are there any professional or trade associations that you suggest I connect with?
- What do you read—in print and online—to keep up with developments in your field?
- What does a typical day look like for you?
- How has running a company (writing a book, starting a blog, etc.) differed from your expectations? What have been the greatest moments and biggest challenges?
- What advice would you give someone entering this field?
- What do you think of the experience I've had so far in terms of entering this field?
 - Ask this only if you've already discussed what experience you have. Take note of what you lack so you can set a goal to bridge that gap. Check out our "Identifying and Developing Transferable Skills" program for more detail on this.
- Can you recommend other people I might contact for further information? May I mention your name?

Resources:

Online:

- Alumni = Career Services > Changing Companies, Functions, and Industries > Networking
- E/W = Careers > Market & Prepare Yourself > Prepare to Network

Books (Fisher Career Resource Center):

- *One Phone Call Away* – Jeffrey W. Meshel
- *The 20-Minute Networking Meeting* – Nathan A. Perez and Marcia Ballinger
- *Networking Life a Pro* – Ivan Misner

CareerCast (<https://www.chicagobooth.edu/careercast>):

- *Building Relationships for a Lifetime of Success* – Bob Burg

Other:

- Questions? Contact Career Services by email at boothworks@ChicagoBooth.edu or by calling 312-464-8677.